

Module 5: Climate Change and Migration

Graduate Research Project

Scenario Analysis: Climate Migration Futures for One Region

Overview

Produce a rigorous scenario-planning study of climate-related migration for one region (e.g., the Central American dry corridor, the Sahel, coastal Bangladesh, Pacific island states) and evaluate current policy responses against your scenarios.

Aligned learning outcomes

- Model future climate migration scenarios (Grad 1)
- Evaluate policy responses (Grad 2)

Sample research questions

- Under plausible climate and adaptation assumptions, what migration futures (internal, cross-border, immobility) does the evidence support for your region?
- Which existing policy instruments (national adaptation plans, regional free movement, humanitarian visas) hold up across scenarios?
- Where are the legal protection gaps most acute in each scenario?

Methods

Structured scenario method: define 2 critical uncertainties, build 3–4 scenarios grounded in IPCC, Groundswell, and IOM/UNHCR data, then stress-test at least three policy responses across them. Distinguish projection from speculation explicitly.

IRB / research ethics

Not required — published data and literature only.

Deliverables

- 4,500-word scenario report with a scenario matrix figure
- Policy stress-test table and briefing-note summary (1 page)

Grading rubric

Each criterion is scored at one of four levels, then weighted as shown. The overall grade is the weighted combination of criterion scores. Instructors may adapt weights and descriptors to local requirements.

Criterion (weight)	Exemplary (A)	Proficient (B)	Developing (C)	Beginning (D–F)
Evidentiary grounding of scenarios 30%	Method is rigorous and transparent: evidentiary grounding of scenarios is fully documented, choices are justified, limitations are stated, and another student could replicate the work from what is written.	Method is sound: evidentiary grounding of scenarios is documented and mostly justified, with limitations acknowledged; small gaps would not change the findings.	Method is partial: evidentiary grounding of scenarios is described but under-documented or inconsistently applied, leaving findings plausible but not checkable.	Method is absent or unsound: evidentiary grounding of scenarios is missing, undocumented, or applied so loosely that the findings cannot be trusted.
Methodological transparency — assumptions stated 25%	Method is rigorous and transparent: methodological transparency — assumptions stated is fully documented, choices are justified, limitations are stated, and another student could replicate the work from what is written.	Method is sound: methodological transparency — assumptions stated is documented and mostly justified, with limitations acknowledged; small gaps would not change the findings.	Method is partial: methodological transparency — assumptions stated is described but under-documented or inconsistently applied, leaving findings plausible but not checkable.	Method is absent or unsound: methodological transparency — assumptions stated is missing, undocumented, or applied so loosely that the findings cannot be trusted.
Quality of the policy stress-test 30%	Analysis is genuinely insightful: quality of the policy stress-test goes beyond summary to produce non-obvious, well-defended conclusions; concepts are applied accurately, complexity is preserved, and counterpoints are engaged seriously.	Analysis is competent: quality of the policy stress-test is achieved with clear reasoning and accurate use of course concepts, though conclusions stay near the expected.	Analysis is thin: quality of the policy stress-test is attempted but leans on summary or assertion; concepts are named more than used, and complications are avoided.	Analysis is absent: quality of the policy stress-test is not achieved; the work describes without analyzing or draws conclusions its own material does not support.

Criterion (weight)	Exemplary (A)	Proficient (B)	Developing (C)	Beginning (D–F)
Communication and figures 15%	Communication is publication-ready: communication and figures is achieved with precise, well-organized prose, correct citation, and figures or formats that make the argument easier to grasp.	Communication is clear and professional: communication and figures is achieved with minor lapses in polish, organization, or citation that never obscure meaning.	Communication is understandable but rough: communication and figures is only partly achieved — disorganization, citation errors, or unclear figures make the reader work to follow the argument.	Communication impedes the work: communication and figures is not achieved; errors, disorganization, or missing citations obscure the substance.